

LB PHOTOS



A Hurried Huddle

GUWAHATI After years of washing dirty linen in public, regional political parties in Assam are coming together once again to oust arch-rival, the Congress, from power. The arrival of Prafulla Kumar Mahanta, Atul Bora and Pabindra Deka at the Ambari office of Asom Gana Parishad (AGP) on May 5 came as the first step in this direction. The three former AGP leaders were there to hold parleys with the 11-member unification committee formed by AGP to facilitate a mer-

ger of its splinter groups.

According to Mahanta, who formed AGP(P) after being expelled from AGP in 2005 for indulging in anti-party activity, it was a step in the right direction. "The ice has been broken, but there are several rounds of discussions to be held still," he said. However, his return to the party he had once founded is being opposed not only by the All Assam Students' Union (AASU) but also by some AGP insiders including President Brindaban Goswami. Though AGP MP

REGIONAL FERVOUR: Mahanta (right)

Sarbananda Sonowal says that the party stands united on this issue, party spokesperson Apurba Kumar Bhattacharya told INDIA TODAY that there is resentment among the party workers on the proposed unification.

AASU is opposing Mahanta's inclusion due to his failure to implement the 1985 Assam Accord and rid the state of illegal Bangladeshi migrants during his two terms as chief minister. Besides, it is now an open secret that he was the chief patron of the "secret killings" of relatives of several ULFA leaders between 1998 and 2001.

Interestingly, the main target of this resurgence—the Congress—scoffs at the proposed union of regional parties. "In the recent Panchayat elections, AGP got 17 per cent of popular votes, AGP(P) got 4 per cent while the Congress got 37 per cent. So, even if they unite, they can't match our strength," says Health Minister Himanta Biswa Sharma. **by Kaushik Deka**

SIGNPOSTS

WON: The Asia Cup for the fourth time in a row by the **Indian women cricket team**. The BCCI has announced a cash prize of Rs 5 lakh each for the 15 members of the squad.

HONOURED: Punjabi singer **Malkit Singh** by Queen Elizabeth II. He has been named as a Member of the British Empire in a ceremony in the Buckingham Palace.



ARRESTED: Fraud godman **Swami Amrita Chaitanya** by the Kerala Police. He faces a Red Corner notice issued in 2004 and is wanted in various cheating and fraud cases in India and abroad.

ACQUITTED: Tamil Nadu chief minister M. Karunanidhi's son **M.K. Azhagiri** in the Kirutinan murder case.

DISMISSED: Jessica Lal murder convict **Manu Sharma's** bail petition by the Supreme Court.

VIS-A-VIS **BUDDHADEB BHATTACHARYA** West Bengal chief minister **versus** **MANMOHAN SINGH** prime minister

The entire country has been suffering due to the prime minister's lack of decision-making power.



SAURABH SINGH

This is politics. We are getting nearer to the elections. Therefore, issues are being politicised.

EPILOGUE: Elections or no elections, most issues and non-issues usually end up being politicised.